# BUILD6™ — Ambassador Christian School
# Week 6: Your First $45,000 Job

## Portfolio Artifact

**Date:** September 24, 2026

**BUILD6 Stage:** DEVELOP™

**Experience Alignment:** Real-life salary, budgeting, benefits, choices and adult financial decisions.

## Portfolio Artifact

Students save the artifact, explain what it shows, and connect it to their Capstone story.

## Locked Weekly Curriculum

© 2026 BUILD6™. All Rights Reserved.

Proprietary Future Ready™ / BUILD6™ program material.

Future Ready™ · Week 6

YOUR FIRST $45,000 JOB

Life · Money · Choices · Tradeoffs · Financial Stability

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

**What does earning $45,000 actually mean for the life I want to build?**

---

THIS WEEK

You landed your first full-time job.

Your annual salary is:

$45,000

That sounds like a lot of money.

But your salary is not the same as the amount of money you actually have available to spend.

Taxes, insurance, benefits, transportation, housing, food, savings, emergencies and everyday choices all affect what your paycheck can actually support.

This week is not about creating a perfect budget.

It is about experiencing the decisions.

---

PART 1 · GROSS PAY IS NOT TAKE-HOME PAY

Annual salary

$45,000

Monthly gross pay

Do not assume this is your spendable income.

$ _____

Monthly take-home amount provided by your facilitator

$ _____

Difference between gross monthly pay and take-home pay

$ _____

Why might those numbers be different?

_____

_____

Before today, did you think about salary in gross pay or actual take-home pay?

_____

What surprised you?

_____

---

PART 2 · BUILD THE LIFE

Your facilitator will provide your realistic monthly take-home amount.

Now build your month.

Do not simply choose the cheapest possible life.

Make choices based on what you think you would realistically want, need and value.

HOUSING

Rent / housing:

$ _____

Utilities:

$ _____

Internet:

$ _____

Roommate?

[ ] Yes

[ ] No

Why?

_____

TRANSPORTATION

Car payment / transportation:

$ _____

Gas:

$ _____

Auto insurance:

$ _____

Maintenance / repairs:

$ _____

DAILY LIFE

Phone:

$ _____

Groceries:

$ _____

Eating out:

$ _____

Clothing:

$ _____

Health / medical:

$ _____

Personal care:

$ _____

LIFE + FUN

Entertainment:

$ _____

Subscriptions:

$ _____

Travel / experiences:

$ _____

Sports / fitness:

$ _____

Other:

$ _____

FUTURE YOU

Savings:

$ _____

Emergency fund:

$ _____

Retirement / long-term savings:

$ _____

Debt / payments:

$ _____

Giving / helping others:

$ _____

Other future goal:

$ _____

---

TOTAL MONTHLY SPENDING

$ _____

MONEY REMAINING

$ _____

If the number is negative, that matters.

If the number is positive, decide what happens to the money.

_____

---

PART 3 · NEED, WANT OR FLEXIBLE?

Not every expense fits perfectly into one category.

Choose several expenses from your plan.

EXPENSE 1

Expense:

_____

[ ] Need

[ ] Want

[ ] Flexible

Why?

_____

EXPENSE 2

Expense:

_____

[ ] Need

[ ] Want

[ ] Flexible

Why?

_____

EXPENSE 3

Expense:

_____

[ ] Need

[ ] Want

[ ] Flexible

Why?

_____

EXPENSE 4

Expense:

_____

[ ] Need

[ ] Want

[ ] Flexible

Why?

_____

Which category was hardest to decide?

_____

Why?

_____

---

PART 4 · YOUR VALUES SHOW UP IN YOUR MONEY

A budget is not just numbers.

It reflects priorities.

What did you choose to spend MORE on because it matters to you?

_____

_____

What did you reduce or give up?

_____

_____

What expense did you underestimate before doing this activity?

_____

What expense felt less important once you saw the whole budget?

_____

Does this monthly plan support the kind of life you want?

[ ] Yes

[ ] Mostly

[ ] Not really

Explain.

_____

_____

---

PART 5 · NOW LIFE HAPPENS

Your facilitator will give you an unexpected event.

Examples could involve:

- car repair
- medical expense
- rent increase
- phone replacement
- reduced work hours
- family obligation
- travel need
- insurance cost
- unexpected opportunity
- emergency

MY EVENT

_____

COST

$ _____

Can your current plan absorb it?

[ ] Yes

[ ] Barely

[ ] No

What has to change?

_____

_____

What do you reduce first?

_____

What do you refuse to cut?

_____

Why?

_____

Revised monthly spending

$ _____

Revised money remaining

$ _____

---

PART 6 · FINANCIAL STABILITY

Think beyond simply “having enough money.”

What does financial stability mean to you now?

_____

_____

Why does an emergency fund matter?

_____

_____

What happens when someone has no financial margin?

_____

_____

What is one financial decision that can create future freedom?

_____

What is one financial decision that can create future pressure?

_____

---

PART 7 · THE SALARY QUESTION CHANGED

Think back to Week 5 career exploration.

You explored possibilities, industries, roles and pathways.

Now add money to that thinking.

A career can interest me AND still require me to ask:

_____

_____

Besides salary, what else would you want to know about a job offer?

Check anything you would investigate.

[ ] Health insurance

[ ] Retirement benefits

[ ] Paid time off

[ ] Schedule

[ ] Advancement opportunities

[ ] Training

[ ] Job stability

[ ] Location

[ ] Commute

[ ] Remote / hybrid options

[ ] Work culture

[ ] Bonuses / incentives

[ ] Education assistance

[ ] Other: _____

Which THREE matter most to you right now?

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Why?

_____

_____

---

PART 8 · PREP FOR BRAD McMILLAN

Next, you will have the opportunity to learn from a financial professional.

Do not arrive with generic questions you could search online.

Use what happened during this activity.

The hardest decision I made today was:

_____

The part of money I understand LESS than I thought I did:

_____

Something about a first salary that surprised me:

_____

Something I want a financial professional to explain:

_____

---

BUILD YOUR MONEY QUESTIONS

QUESTION 1

_____

Why do I want to know this?

_____

QUESTION 2

_____

Why do I want to know this?

_____

QUESTION 3

_____

Why do I want to know this?

_____

QUESTION 4

_____

QUESTION 5

_____

My strongest question for Brad:

_____

_____

---

PART 9 · MY MONEY RULE

Based on what you experienced today, complete this:

When I begin earning full-time income, I want to remember...

_____

_____

One financial habit I want to build:

_____

One habit I want to avoid:

_____

One thing I want to learn before signing a financial agreement:

_____

---

WEEK 6 REFLECTION

BEFORE THIS ACTIVITY...

I thought a $45,000 salary meant:

_____

_____

NOW...

I understand:

_____

_____

The decision that challenged me most:

_____

The tradeoff I did not expect:

_____

Something my spending choices revealed about my values:

_____

Something I want to do differently with money:

_____

---

FUTURE READY™ PASSPORT EVIDENCE

Save:

MY ORIGINAL MONTHLY PLAN

Completed: [ ]

MY REVISED PLAN AFTER THE UNEXPECTED EVENT

Completed: [ ]

ONE FINANCIAL VALUE

_____

ONE LIFE PRIORITY

_____

ONE MONEY HABIT

_____

ONE FINANCIAL GOAL

_____

MY STRONGEST QUESTION FOR BRAD

_____

---

CAPSTONE CONNECTION

Keep:

- your original monthly plan
- your revised plan
- one financial value
- one life priority
- one financial habit
- one financial goal
- one decision that changed after seeing the numbers
- one question you want a financial professional to answer

Money is one part of building your future.

Your choices, habits, values and ability to adapt matter too.

---

WEEK 6 CLOSE

Complete each statement.

I EXPECTED...

_____

I DID NOT EXPECT...

_____

I HAD TO CHOOSE...

_____

I REALIZED...

_____

I WANT TO ASK...

_____

MY MONEY RULE IS...

_____

---

**EARN. CHOOSE. ADAPT. PLAN. BUILD WHAT'S NEXT.**

© 2026 BUILD6™. All Rights Reserved.

Proprietary Future Ready™ / BUILD6™ program material.

BUILD6™ — Proprietary curriculum of LINK Lake Norman, LLC.